People's Person



KRISHNENDU HALDER

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Has shown exemplary conviction and empathy in serving the citizenry

ON JANUARY 10, WHEN THE UNION personnel department relieved Telangana chief secretary Somesh Kumar from the state's service, then chief minister K. Chandrashekar Rao picked the self-effacing A. Santhi Kumari to occupy the seat. The 1989-batch Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer thus became the first woman at the helm of civil administration, of the six so far, in the country's youngest state.

"It is yet another opportunity to serve people," says Santhi Kumari, who has worked in the fields of poverty alleviation, education, health, skill development and forestry in her three-decade-plus career. It was while pursuing M.Sc. in marine biology from Andhra University, Visakhapatnam, that she came across some seniors preparing for the civil services exam and decided to take it. "It became a turning point from the routine academics to an exciting career," she recalls. "I discovered a new me in the process."

Spirituality being an integral part of her upbringing, Santhi Kumari believes that "we are here to serve and show compassion to the needy". And that's the "dictum", she says, she has always followed in her personal and professional life. Twenty-five years ago, posted as district collector of Adilabad, Santhi Kumari did all she could to end the exploitation of cotton farmers—from preventing black marketing of seeds to ensuring proper weighing and fair market procurement. While this ruffled the feathers of black marketeers, the young IAS officer was transferred out from Adilabad. Suspecting a correlation between these two developments, the local farmers observed a three-day bandh to protest her transfer. "Our work can have an unimaginable impact on people," she says, "and to this day, Adilabad cotton farmers send me their good wishes."

During a two-year stint with the United Nations Development Programme, the senior bureaucrat worked as chief operating officer (COO) of the National Livelihood Mission, travelling across the country to ensure the financial inclusion of self-help groups. "Sitting in Delhi, we can't micromanage a national mission," she says. "It's not only impossible, but also not desirable."

Her message to young administrators? A whole litany, as it turns out—"Pay attention to detail, yet see the big picture; treat every member of the team as important and valuable; keep the larger good in mind; stay empathetic; remain an active listener." ■

–Amarnath K. Menon

LETTING GO

"A boat is always safe at the harbour, but it is never meant to be there"

ROLE MODEL The late legendary civil servant S.R. Sankaran and his work for tribal welfare and abolition of bonded labour